# Lech Lecha 5785

This דבר תורה is dedicated in honor of our אייניקל Tzvi Asher Bennett, whose birthday is on פרשת לך לך. Around the time he was born, he had a ברית, like every other יידיש boy.

We know that ספר בראשית has only three of all the תרי״ג מצוות, one of which is ברית מילה, at the very end of פרשת לך לך. I've always enjoyed finding insights at the end of the פרשה to give it some special חשיבות, since most divrei Torah focus on the beginning. So here, we'll talk about ברית מילה.

Interestingly, as I was preparing, it occurred to me that the three מצוות in Sefer Bereshis - פריה ורביה, ברית מילה, and גיד הנשה - are foundational מצוות, each integral to Jewish life. ברית מילה, in particular, requires little introduction or explanation; it is a mitzvah that every Jewish family ensures for their sons, unless, of course, there is an unavoidable health issue. ברית מילה is the cornerstone of our covenant, going back to אברהם אבינו. While all מצוות were formally given to us as a nation at הר סיני, ברית מילה originates with אברהם אבינו, and even though it was reconfirmed at הר סיני, it is inherently a מצוה of ספר בראשית.

In connection with ברית מילה, the ספר אוצר פלאות התורה includes an incredible מעשה that took place involving the חת"ם סופר. I thought sharing this מעשה would be a meaningful gift for our birthday boy, Tzvi Bennett. This מעשה פלא comes from a ספר called זכרון למשה, and tells a fascinating story about performing a ברית מילה on a goy.

The story goes that during the time of the חת"ם סופר, a goy from a small hamlet near Pressburg, where the חת"ם סופר lived, approached the rav of his town. The goy expressed a sincere desire to become a ger. After examining his intentions and confirming that he was לשם שמים, the rav performed a conversion כדת וכדין, including a ברית מילה. However, on the third day after his מילה, the ger fell seriously ill.

The local doctors could not cure him, and they declared that he would die. This illness caused a great disturbance among his goyish relatives, who accused the Jews of killing him with their ברית מילה. Their accusations escalated into a סכנה, not only for that town but as a threat of a nationwide pogrom.

Desperate, the rav sought guidance and went to Pressburg to consult the חת"ם סופר. The חת"ם סופר strongly reprimanded him, asking how he could perform a ברית מילה in such a small town without the necessary expertise or medical facilities, risking everyone's safety. However, since the deed was done, the חת"ם סופר advised him on how to address this dangerous situation.

He told the rav that because he had endangered כלל ישראל, he must be מוסר נפש for the welfare of the community. The חת"ם סופר instructed the rav to take the ger and the מוהל in a wagon to a nearby river, and to stage an accident by driving the wagon into the water, drowning them all. This way, the goyim would believe the man had died from an accident, not from the ברית מילה, and the community would be saved from the threat of retaliation.

https://youtu.be/VyUpz8CQheU

With a profound acceptance of his duty to כלל ישראל, the rav, along with the מוהל, prepared for this act of self-sacrifice. They said וידוי, took the wagon, and began their journey toward the river with the gravely ill ger. On the way, a Jew suddenly appeared and stopped them, urging them not to proceed. The rav explained their mission, and the stranger revealed himself as a תלמיד חכם. He assured them he had a remedy, producing a flask containing a special liquid. He instructed them to apply it to the ברית מילה, promising it would heal the ger.

They followed his instructions, and immediately, the ger's health improved, sparing the rav and מוהל from the need for self-sacrifice. The entire town rejoiced, and peace was restored.

When the rav and the מוהל returned to the חת"ם סופר to recount the events, he revealed that he had sent אליהו, the מלאך הברית, to intervene and save the ger. The חת"ם סופר explained that they merited this miraculous assistance only because they had been willing to be מוסר נפש for כלל ישראל. In essence, he knew from the start that they would be protected, fulfilling the promise that כי שומר מצוה לא ידע דבר רע - those who fulfill מצוות will be shielded from harm.

Bezras Hashem, we should all be protected. May we be blessed to observe all מצוות, especially the מצוה of ברית מילה, for which כלל ישראל has always shown self-sacrifice. May we soon witness גאולה and the coming of משיח במהרה בימינו אמן!

https://youtu.be/VyUpz8CQheU